The Price of Flexibility

What PMEs value, what employers weigh, and where they meet

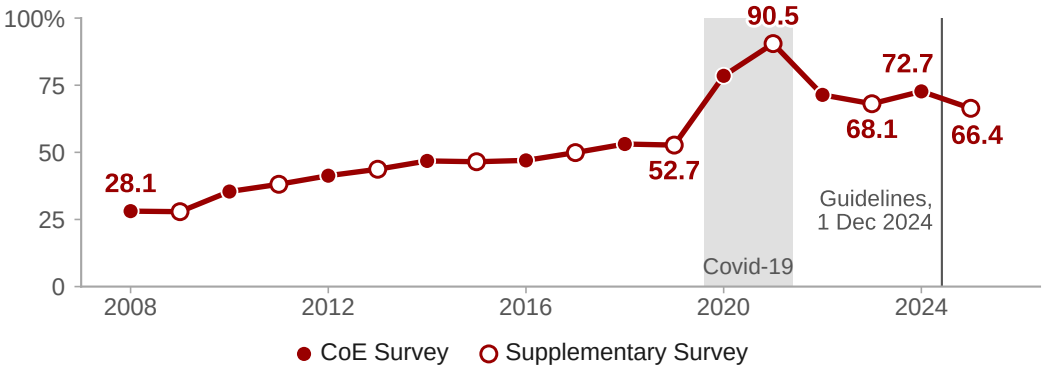
Seonghoon Kim

Singapore Management University

Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

Preliminary findings for tripartite discussion | January 2027

Flexible work is mainstream; the policy problem is fit



Aggregate provision does not show whether firms offer the arrangements workers value.

Share of establishments (25+ staff, incl. public sector) offering a scheduled FWA. **Source:** MRSD, MOM (Jun 2026).

▸ Labour supply ▸ Guidelines

The open problem is fit, not whether a process exists

Arrangement fit

Aggregate provision masks which arrangements are available, and whether they fit the worker and the role.

Two sides, measured together

Worker value and employers' hiring reservations are rarely measured together.

Barriers

Career, information and redesign barriers can block mutually beneficial use.

Which arrangements create common ground, for which roles, and what blocks adoption?

▸ Guidelines ▸ Partners

What is known, and what this study adds

	Known so far	This study adds
Workers	WFH is worth **4–8%** of pay (Singapore 4.8%, asked directly in a 27-country survey). Other FWAs not measured.	**Six more FWAs** besides WFH
Employers	One study, in Poland, on WFH only: employers expect a **21%** wage cut, workers give up **2.9%**.	Employers' values, **measured the same way** as workers'
Singapore	Surveys cover FWA use and provision. **No study measures what FWAs are worth.**	**FWA values estimated for Singapore**, both sides on one scale: the **gap**

References: Mas & Pallais 2017; Maestas et al. 2023; Aksoy et al. 2022; Lewandowski et al. 2023; MRSD 2024; SNEF–SUSS 2025.

▸ Studies ▸ Benchmarks ▸ Trials

We surveyed 1,020 PMEs and 397 employers

1,020 PMEs

Singapore citizens and PRs in or seeking PME roles

Online panels, unweighted

Fielded 4–21 Aug 2026

397 employer respondents

People involved in PME hiring or manpower decisions

Online panel, unweighted

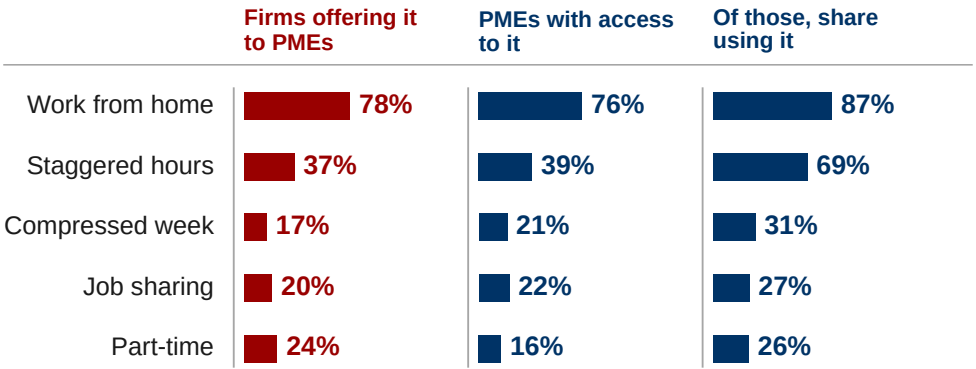
Fielded 12 Aug–2 Oct 2026

Employer respondents' firms, by staff size



Sample

WFH is the common FWA; the others reach fewer PMEs



Most PMEs can work from home and most do; the other arrangements are open to far fewer. Even where available, only 3 in 10 use the compressed week, job sharing or part-time.

With access: PMEs who say it is available to them or already use it.

Both sides chose between the same kinds of options

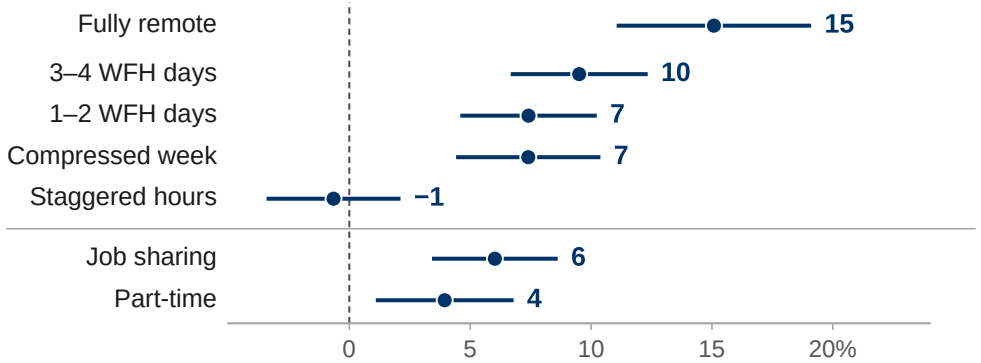
PMEs choose a job		Common menu	Employers choose a hire	
Job Offer A	**Job Offer B**		**Candidate A**	**Candidate B**
+10% vs own pay	**−10%** vs own pay	**Monthly pay**	**+10%** vs last PME hire	**−10%** vs last PME hire
Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH	**Work location**	Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH
Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week	**Work schedule**	Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week
Same in both: as in own job		**Everything else**	Same in both: as in own firm	

Two attributes differ in each choice; which ones, and their levels, are randomized.

From six choices each, we estimate the **% of pay** each side would give up or require.

▸ Choice cards ▸ Sample

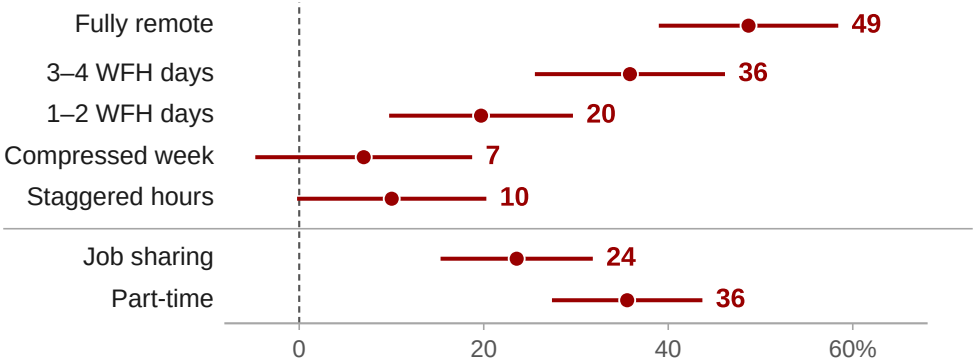
PMEs place a high value on remote work



PMEs value remote work most, and more with each extra day.
A compressed week is worth as much as 1–2 days at home; staggered hours are not valued.

▸ Benchmarks ▸ Checks ▸ PME groups

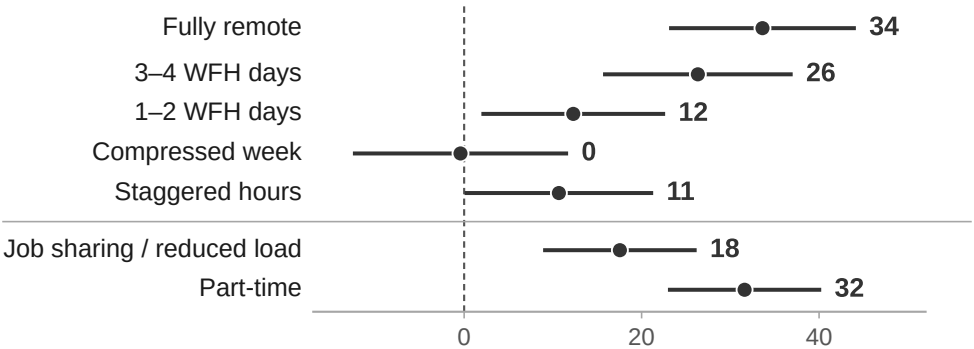
Employers expect a pay cut, biggest for fully remote work



Employers expect the biggest cut for fully remote work, and a large one for part-time. A compressed week or staggered hours draw the smallest cuts.

▸ Numbers ▸ Checks

The two sides' values meet only for the compressed week



Only for the compressed week do the two sides agree (about 7% each).
For WFH, employers expect a pay cut 12 to 34 points larger than PMEs would accept.

▸ Numbers ▸ Raw choices

Employers name productivity, coordination and fairness

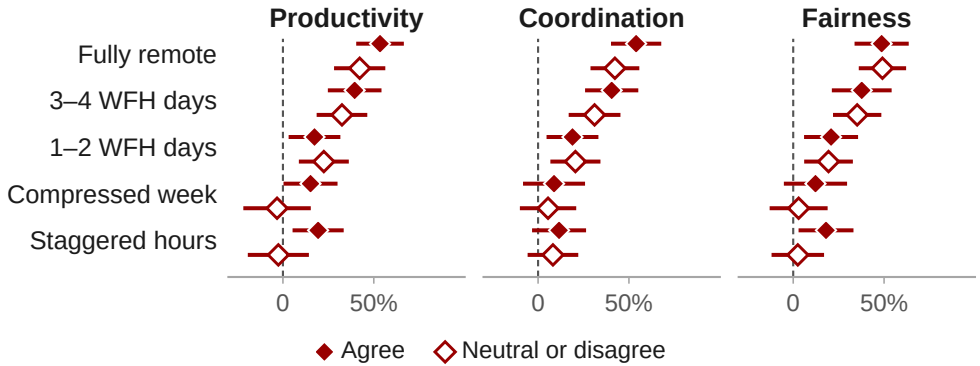


Productivity, coordination and fairness are each named by about a quarter of employers. Digital infrastructure and security matter much less (6% each).

Single biggest challenge per employer.

▸ Employer view

Employers' main concerns do not reliably change the pay cut

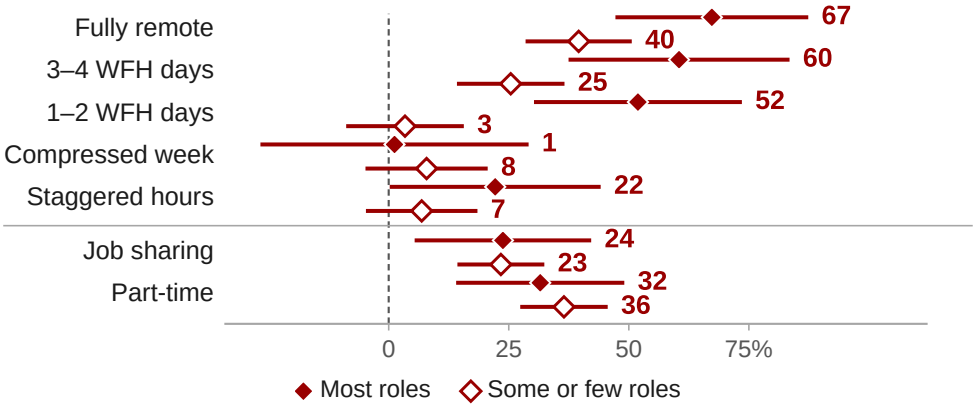


Firms that agree with a concern expect somewhat bigger cuts, but not reliably. Creativity, a fourth concern, shows the clearest signal (see backup).

Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3.

▸ Four concerns ▸ Employer view

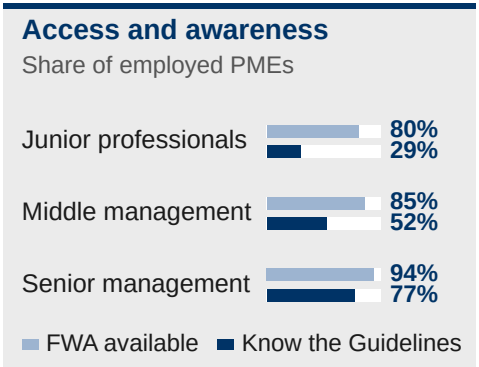
On-site needs raise the WFH pay cut, not the others



Where most roles need on-site presence, the WFH pay cut is 28 to 49 points larger.
Other arrangements show no such difference, yet few firms offer them. Early evidence only.

▸ All splits ▸ Concerns ▸ Other traits ▸ Employer view

All levels value WFH alike, but juniors have less access

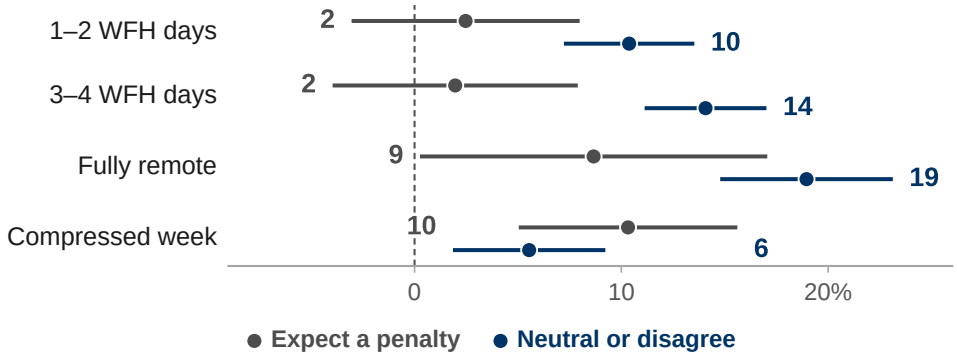




WFH values do not differ clearly by level;
access and familiarity with the Guidelines rise with seniority.

▸ By level ▸ Access ▸ Guidelines

PMEs who fear a career penalty give up much less pay for WFH



45% of PMEs expect flexible work to hurt their career;
they would give up much less pay for working from home.

Expect a penalty: agree (4–5 of 5) that flexible hours would hurt their career.

▸ All splits ▸ Career risk ▸ Use ▸ Value

What we found

Values	PMEs value remote work most, **more with each extra day**; employers expect bigger pay cuts
Common ground	Only the **compressed week** shows no gap between the two sides
Employers	Name **productivity, coordination and fairness** as hurdles, but these do not reliably change the pay cut; **on-site needs** do (WFH)
PMEs	Juniors have **less access** and know the Guidelines least; 45% fear a career penalty

▸ Limits ▸ Robustness

Policy directions

Direction	Based on
A Test the compressed week	No gap; few have access
B Match arrangements to roles	Little WFH cut where roles need no presence
C Support managers and HR	Employer hurdles; career worry
D Open access and information for juniors	Least access, lowest familiarity
E Measure what is missing	Why PMEs do not ask

For discussion: which of these could the partners take forward?

Stated choices from online panels; employer splits are preliminary.

▸ Follow-up ▸ Survey items ▸ Pilot checklist

Thank you

Questions and discussion

Seonghoon Kim · Singapore Management University
Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

▸ Backup index

Backup index: likely questions

Policy and practice

- Did the Guidelines change outcomes?
- Should FWA requests be legislated?
- Is this a burden for smaller firms?
- How would a compressed-week pilot run?
- Why do some PMEs not ask?
- Do all job levels have the same access?
- What next, and with whose consent?

The evidence

- Is the career risk real?
- Are reservations about roles or concerns?
- Is the compressed-week result a design artefact?
- Can employer reservations be priced?

The study

- Do stated choices predict behaviour?

Full backup index | Summary | Thank you

Full backup index

Background
Studies · Benchmarks
Evidence abroad · Rules abroad
Landscape · Pathways · Surveys
Labour supply · Guidelines
Partners' views · Vs ours

Data and design
Sample · Industries
Choice cards · Pay gaps
Why not pay data · Estimation
Equations · Validity · Dominance

PME values
All estimates · Numbers · Commute
Group differences · Other splits
Gender · Age · Care
Role · Education
Access · Users vs others

Employer values
Raw choices · Salary lever
All splits · Four concerns
Concerns · Other traits · Own view

Compressed week
Valued, rarely offered · Design
Flexi-load · Pilot checklist

Barriers
Career risk · Who expects it
Use by view · Value by view
By level · Guidelines · Awareness
Approvals · Request rate

Robustness
Summary · PMEs · Employers

Limits and directions
Limits · Follow-up
Direction A B C D E
E: survey items

Likely questions · Thank you

Backup index

Backup B2

Studies behind the benchmarks and the question

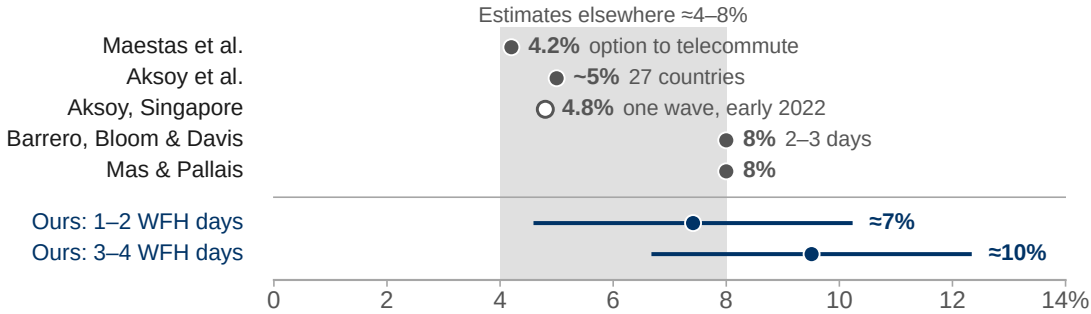
Study	Setting	What it finds
Mas & Pallais (2017)	US call-centre applicants	Give up 8% of wages for the option to work from home
Aksoy et al. (2022)	27-country online survey (Singapore: higher education)	One direct question on 2–3 WFH days; Singapore 4.8%, average 5.0%
Maestas et al. (2023)	US workers	WFH worth about 4% of pay; own schedule about 9%
Lewandowski et al. (2023)	Poland, both sides	Workers give up 2.9%, employers expect a 21% wage cut (pooled)
Aum, Kim & Lee (2025)	3,026 Korean workers	Horizontal culture valued most; a precedent for pricing job attributes
Wang & Dong (2024)	Singapore, young unmarried workers	Flexible work raises fertility intentions, most for women and professionals
MRSD Conditions of Employment (2024)	Singapore firms; regressions	Larger, PMET-heavy firms offer more FWAs; better outcomes for flexi-hours and telework than part-time
SNEF–SUSS report (2025)	Singapore employers	Practices, benefits and drawbacks; no pay trade-offs

◂ Slide 4 ◂ Estimates abroad

Backup index

Backup B3

PME values at or above estimates abroad



Not like-for-like: populations, methods and definitions differ.

◂ PMEs ◂ Studies

Backup index

Backup B4

Evidence elsewhere: concerns and trials

- **Poland, two-sided experiment:** workers give up 2.9% of pay for remote work; employers expect a 21% wage cut, mostly for lost productivity (Lewandowski et al., IZA DP 16041, 2023; hybrid and fully remote pooled). ILR Review (2026) version: gaps $\approx$ 5% (hybrid), 25% (fully remote).
- **Randomised hybrid trial** (two days a week; 1,612 graduates, one Chinese firm): quits fell by one-third over six months; over two years, reviews were unaffected and promotions showed no statistically significant difference; managers' productivity view: -2.6% to $+1.0\%$ (Bloom, Han & Liang, Nature 2024; co-author J. Liang co-founded Trip.com).
- **Singapore firms offering scheduled FWAs:** 69.5% report better engagement, 65.9% retention, 59.9% productivity (employer-reported, mid-2024; MRSD).
- **Fully remote:** evidence is mixed and job-dependent; several studies find lower productivity, partly reflecting who selects into remote jobs (Barrero, Bloom & Davis 2023; Emanuel & Harrington 2024).

◂ Slide 4 ◂ Directions

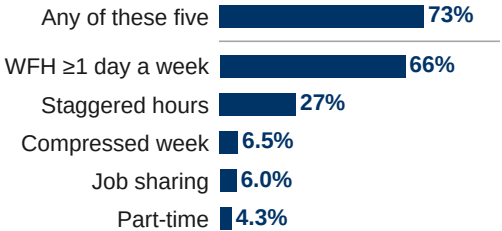
Backup index

Backup B5

Flexible work today: PMEs and firms

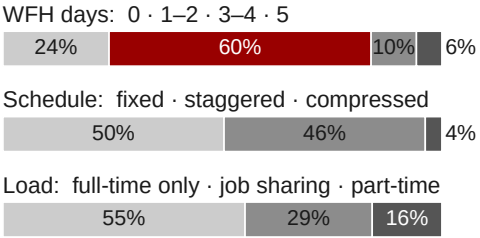
PMEs: current use

% of employed PMEs



Employers: typical PME arrangement

% of employers



Practice
Puzzle
Backup index
Backup B6

Most FWAs come via policy or request

PMEs: how FWA was set up (N = 869)	%	Employers (N = 397)	%
Company-wide policy (automatic)	43	Written policy: all firms	70
Individual request	30	... 200 or fewer staff	63
Informal, with manager	18	... 201–1,000 staff	73
Negotiated in contract	5	... 1,001 or more staff	78
Don't know	5	... size test (p)	.027
		Got formal requests: with policy[1]	68
		... without policy	19

[1] Firms aware of the Guidelines.

◂ Practice ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B7

Official surveys: demand, provision and penalties

Required and provided, 2024

32% / 23% / 21%
required scheduled tele-working, flexible hours, choice of days off

72% / 67% / 75%
of those who required each were provided with it

Felt penalised for taking up FWAs, 2020

9%
of employees felt penalised

34 / 29 / 29
of them: fewer training opportunities / reduced benefits / passed over for promotion

Sources: MRSD, Report on Employees' Working Conditions (May 2026); Work-Life Harmony Report 2020.

◂ Practice ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

Backup B8

Keeping people in work matters more

67.9%
resident participation, 2025 (fourth straight fall)

3.3 → 2.7
residents 20–64 per resident 65+, 2025 to 2030 (projected)

22.0%
of residents outside the labour force cite housework or caregiving (2025; 24.4% in 2020)

80.5%
female participation, ages 25–64 (2025)

< half
who needed part-time work got it (2024; COS 2026)

5.9% vs 13.7%
share of all women 25–64 in part-time work: Singapore (2025) vs OECD (2024)

Sources: MRSD Labour Force in Singapore 2025; MOM COS 2026; Labour Market Report 2Q 2026.

◂ Motivation

Backup index

Backup B9

The Guidelines: process, not outcome

1. Request	→ 2. Proper consideration	→ 3. Written decision
In writing by default	On business needs	Within 2 months; reasons if declined

In effect from 1 Dec 2024 for employees past probation. A significant cost burden or customer needs can be business grounds to decline; a preference for face time, or refusing to avoid similar requests from others, cannot. TAFEP takes an educational approach, guiding employers to comply (MOM, 2026).

MOM indicators, 2024 data: not one funnel; definitions differ

84.5%
who needed a scheduled FWA got one they needed

≈ 94%
of requests approved; base not defined

18.5%
of those in need asked formally; 26.3% informally

Full-time residents aged 25–64, almost entirely before the Guidelines; MOM reads the gap as "frictions", not employer resistance. Firms need not report requests to MOM. Establishments (25+ staff) offering a scheduled FWA: 72.7% (Jun 2024), 66.4% (Jun 2025; another MOM survey; not attributed to the Guidelines).

Sources: Tripartite Guidelines (2024); MRSD (2026); MOM PQ replies; COS 2026.

◂ Question ◂ Motivation

Backup index

Backup B10

FWA request rules elsewhere

- **Singapore:** tripartite guidelines on the process, not the outcome; TAFEP takes an educational approach.
- **Great Britain:** statutory right to request from day one (since Apr 2024); decision within 2 months; refusal only on eight listed business reasons; a tribunal if a request is not handled reasonably, not merely if refused. Employment Rights Act 2025 changes due in 2027.
- **Australia:** eligible employees (e.g. parents, carers, 55+); written reply within 21 days; refusal only on reasonable business grounds; the Fair Work Commission can arbitrate and, as a last resort, order it granted. **New Zealand:** any employee; reply within 1 month; eight listed grounds; disputes cover process only. In both, most requests are informal.
- **Why guidelines here:** the Workgroup judged legislation risks an acrimonious workplace culture; at COS 2026, MOM called legislating the Guidelines, with a presumptive FWA right for parents of young children, too blunt.

Sources: MOM COS 2026, FAQ; Workgroup report (2024); gov.uk/flexible-working; Fair Work Act 2009; Employment Relations Act 2000 (NZ).

What each partner has said

- **MOM:** reads the need-request gap as “frictions … rather than employer resistance”; at COS 2026 called a proposal to make the Guidelines law, and FWAs a presumptive right for parents of young children, “too blunt”, as business needs differ by industry and role.
- **SNEF:** endorses the Guidelines on three principles: outcomes stay the employer’s prerogative; FWAs must not harm productivity or service quality; not every role suits every FWA. SUSS×SNEF (367 firms, 2024): 81% felt prepared.
- **NTUC:** FWA access is often the main consideration for caregivers, women and senior workers in staying in or returning to work. PAP Women’s Wing–NTUC survey (online, N = 1,508; sampling not published): 36% named stigma their primary concern in requesting an FWA (most cited).

Sources: MRSD (2026); MOM COS 2026 (3 Mar 2026); SNEF statement (23 Apr 2024); SUSS–SNEF (2025); MOM release (16 Apr 2024); PAP Women’s Wing, NTUC (Mar 2026).

◂ Question

Backup index

Backup B12

Partners' evidence and ours

Source	They found	We find
MOM, Working Conditions 2024	$\approx$ 94% of requests approved; 18.5% ask formally	4% of PMEs' formal requests declined outright (a lower bound)
MOM, CoE 2024	Firms with scheduled FWAs report gains: engagement 69.5%, retention 65.9%, productivity 59.9%	66% of employers: FWAs help attract and retain talent
PAP Women's Wing–NTUC (2025)[a]	36% name stigma the main concern; 58% aware; 89% of formal applicants approved, fully or with changes	45% expect a career penalty; 83% aware (55% familiar); 96% of formal requests approved, fully or partly
SUSS$\times$SNEF (2024)	81% felt prepared; 22% thought they must approve every request	58% of employers familiar; 36% more have heard of them

[a] Online survey, N = 1,508; sampling not published. Populations and questions differ: read as direction.

◂ Motivation ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B13

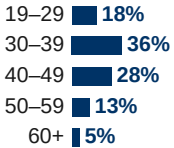
Who answered

PMEs (n = 1,020)

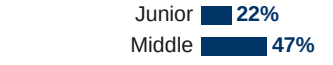
Gender



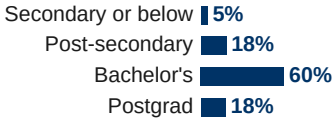
Age



Role

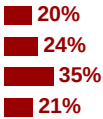


Education

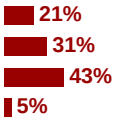


Employers (n = 397)

Firm size (staff)



Role



Design Data

Backup index

Backup B14

Respondents span the main industries



% of each sample; sorted by PME share.

Employed PMEs (n = 1,004), employers (n = 397). Employer industry cells hold 4 to 60 firms, too few for industry estimates.

Data

Nearly the same cards on both sides

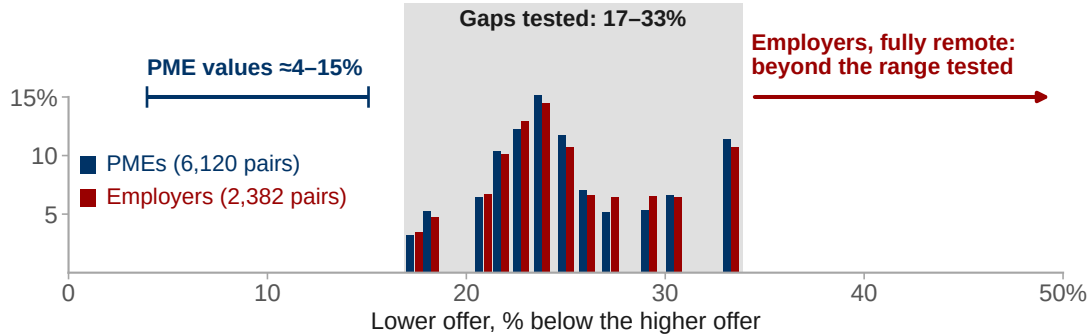
Attribute	PMEs (job offers)	Employers (candidates)
Salary	Own salary $\times$ multiplier	Latest PME-hire salary $\times$ multiplier
Location	Onsite; 1–2 WFH days a week; 3–4 days; fully remote	Same
Schedule	Fixed 9am–6pm; staggered; compressed 4-day week (same hours, longer days)	Same
Workload	Full-time (35–44 h); *job sharing (4 days)*; part-time ($<$35 h)	Full-time; *reduced load (4 days)*; part-time
Risk	Job loss (low / moderate / high)	Turnover (low $<$10% / moderate / high $>$20%)
Other	Culture; commute	Culture
Design	6 forced choices between 2 options; each pair differs in salary and two attributes, the rest held at the respondent's own practice. Multipliers 0.80–0.95 vs 1.05–1.20, closest pairs never drawn: every gap is 17–33%. 10 versions.	

Employers were told both candidates are equally qualified.

◂ Design

Backup index

Every pair differed in pay by 17–33%



Design Estimation

Backup index

Backup B17

Pay data cannot price flexibility

Current arrangement (vs onsite / full-time)	Observed pay difference, %	Value in the experiment, % of pay
1–2 days WFH	+37	≈7
3–4 days WFH	+36	≈10
Fully remote[1]	+42	≈15
Part-time	−53	≈4

[1] Experiment: vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

Log current pay on current arrangement, with controls (N = 991 employed PMEs).

◂ Design

Backup index

Backup B18

How we turn choices into values

Illustrative choice task

Scenario 1 of 6

	Job Offer A	Job Offer B
Monthly pay	**+10%** vs own pay	**–10%** vs own pay
Work location	Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH
Work schedule	Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week

Workload, Job security, Workplace culture, Commute time: same for A and B (your current job)

How values are calculated

1. Choose A or B, six times
2. Estimate how pay and each FWA shift choices
3. Translate it into the **% of pay** each side would give up or require (indicative)

▸ Equations ▸ Validity

Backup index

Backup B19

Equations and inference

$$U_{ijt} = \beta_w \ln w_{ijt} + \sum_k \beta_k x_{kijt} + \varepsilon_{ijt}$$

Conditional logit per side; SEs clustered by respondent.

Pay given up: $100\,[1 - \exp(-\beta_k/\beta_w)]$

For PMEs ($\beta_w > 0$), the pay they would give up for k; for employers ($\beta_w < 0$), the pay cut they would require of a candidate who wants k. Positive = a pay cut. Indicative: gaps shown were 17–33%, and a which-paid-more indicator fits about as well.

Gap: employers' cut − PMEs' give-up

Positive = friction. Its 95% interval combines both sides' delta-method standard errors (independent samples). Employer cuts above 33% go beyond the pay gaps shown, so gaps are indicative.

- **Intervals:** 60 choice situations per side (10 versions $\times$ 6 tasks), so intervals may be too narrow.
- **Pay slopes:** group splits use a separate pay slope for each group. Employers' role and concern items were asked after the choices, so these splits are preliminary associations.
- **Checks:** without outliers, the top and bottom 1% of income or same-side respondents, or with a position term, PME values move $\leq$1.3 points and employer values $\leq$2.5. To fix: task-1 coding ($\approx$0.5 point, remote).

i respondent, j option, t task; w pay shown; x_k arrangement level k. McFadden (1974).

◂ Estimation

Do stated choices predict real choices?

Maestas et al. (AER 2023)	US workers, up to 3 years on: 977 of 1,738 (56%) matched; kept vs lost an amenity: +4.1 pp (1% level); gained: +1.7 pp (n.s.)
Wiswall & Zafar (QJE 2018)	NYU students, about 4 years on (59 working): 6 of 6 links to actual jobs with the expected sign, 3 significant at 5%
Mas & Pallais (AER 2017)	Call-centre applicants: WFH 8.4% of pay, survey (reweighted to field commute times) vs 7.8%, field; scheduling 2.5% vs 2.8%
Hainmueller et al. (PNAS 2015)	Swiss voters: paired conjoint (best of 5 designs) within 2 pp of referendum effects on average (21 effects); levels missed (21% vs 37% rejection)
Health DCE meta-analyses	Opting in predicted well; opting out weakly (pooled specificity 34–52%)

- **Rankings hold best:** direction right and, in one direct test, relative size; our ranking is the firmest result.
- **Levels less so:** rates predicted less well, money values mixed; our % of pay values are indicative.
- **Our design:** one cross-section; pay gaps of 17–33% only; no link yet to behaviour (dominance check).

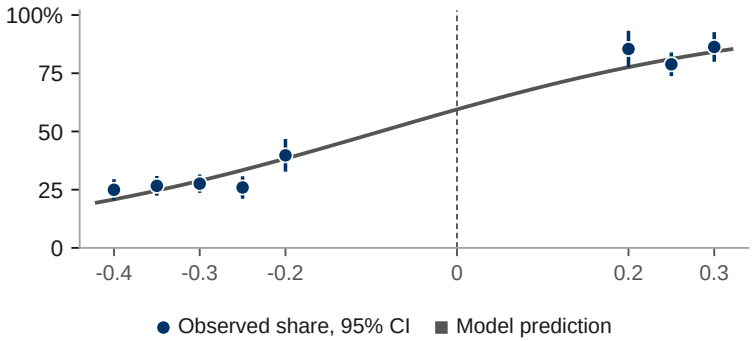
No cited study validates employer hiring choices of this form;
our follow-up addresses only part of that gap.

◂ Estimation ◂ Robustness

Backup index

Backup B21

Dominance check: choices follow pay when one job is clearly better



When the better job paid less, 25–40% still chose it; when it paid more, 79–86% did.

Choice sets where one job is better on both non-salary attributes shown (3,150 of 6,120); x-axis: its salary minus the other job's, log points. Better = fully remote > 3–4 > 1–2 days > onsite; compressed > staggered > fixed; part-time > job sharing > full time; low > moderate > high risk; collaborative > autonomous > mixed > hierarchical; short > moderate > long commute.

◂ Validity ◂ Estimation

Backup index

Backup B22

All PME estimates, % of pay

Level (vs base)	% of pay	95% CI	Status
1–2 days WFH (onsite)	≈7	5–10	Direction robust
3–4 days WFH (onsite)	≈10	7–12	Direction robust
Fully remote (onsite, long commute)	≈15	11–19	≈12 vs moderate, ≈8 vs short commute
Staggered hours (fixed hours)	≈0	−3 to 2	Robust: about zero
Compressed week (fixed hours)	≈7	4–10	Direction robust
Job sharing (full-time)	≈6	3–9	Hours change: not a price
Part-time (full-time)	≈4	1–7	Hours change: not a price
Low job-loss risk (high)	≈5	0–10	*not robust*: ≈2 (n.s.) with position term; ≈9 excl. same-side
Collaborative culture (hierarchical)	≈10	5–14	Context: ≈7 with position term; one task only
Short commute (long commute)	≈8	3–13	Context only

Base level in brackets. N = 1,020. Grey = indicative.

Fully remote is vs a long commute (commute).

◂ PMEs

Offering, use and pay terms: numbers

Arrangement	Firms offer, %	PMEs with access, %	PMEs use, %	Use, if available, %	PMEs give up, %	Employers require, %	Gap, points
Compressed week	17	21	6	31 [25, 38]	7 [4, 10]	7 [−5, 19]	0 [−13, 12], n.s.
1–2 days WFH	78	76	66	87 [85, 89]	7 [5, 10]	20 [10, 30]	12 [2, 23]
3–4 days WFH					10 [7, 12]	36 [26, 46]	26 [16, 37]
Fully remote					15 [11, 19]	49 [39, 58]	34 [23, 44]
Staggered hours	37	39	27	69 [65, 74]	−1 [−3, 2]	10 [0, 20]	11 [0, 21]
Job sharing / reduced load	20	22	6	27 [21, 33]	6 [3, 9]	24 [15, 32]	18 [9, 26]
Part-time	24	16	4	26 [20, 33]	4 [1, 7]	36 [27, 44]	32 [23, 40]

Access: available or already used. Use, if available: share using among PMEs with access. Offer, access and use refer to any WFH (first WFH row). 95% CIs; n.s. = not significant at 5%.

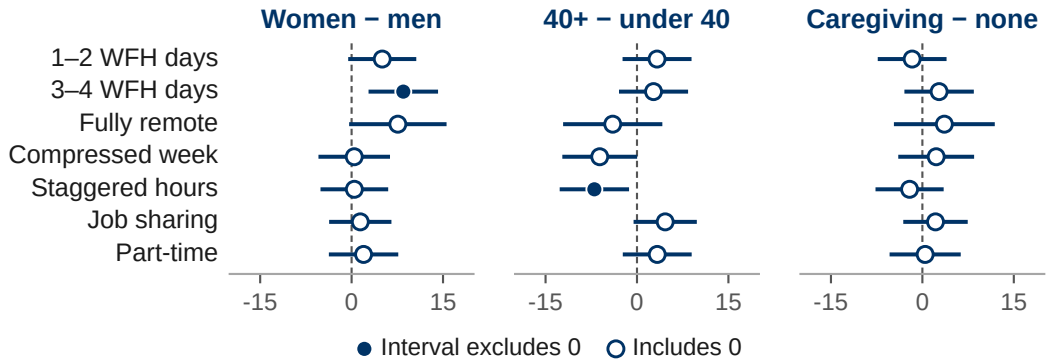
◂ Practice ◂ Two sides

Backup index

Fully remote valued against any commute

Fully remote, compared with onsite work with . . .	% of pay given up [95% CI]
a long commute (>45 min) (main estimate)	15.1 [11.1, 19.1]
a moderate commute (15–45 min)	12.2 [9.0, 15.5]
a short commute (<15 min)	7.5 [2.9, 12.1]

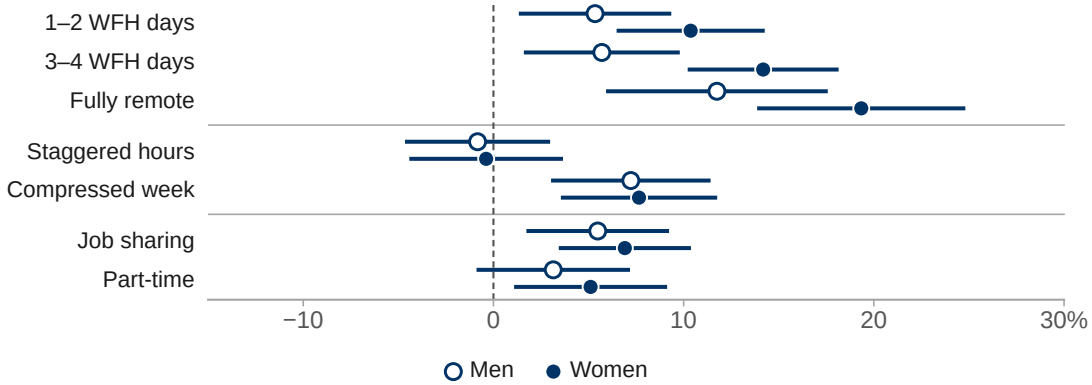
Women give up more for WFH; little else differs



Women give up more for WFH (clearly for 3–4 days); PMEs aged 40+ less for staggered hours. Other differences are small or imprecise.

Second group minus first, 95% CI; not adjusted for repeated comparisons.

Estimates by gender



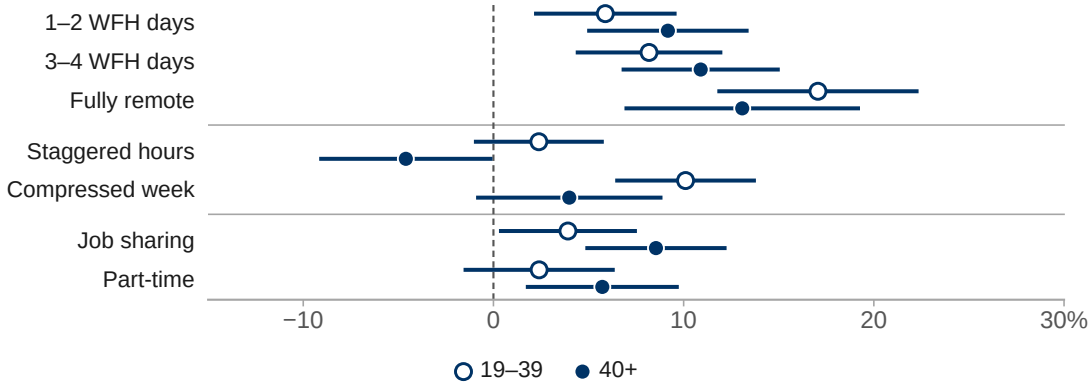
Women give up more for 3–4 WFH days (8 points, $p < .01$); nothing else is significant at 5%.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B27

Estimates by age

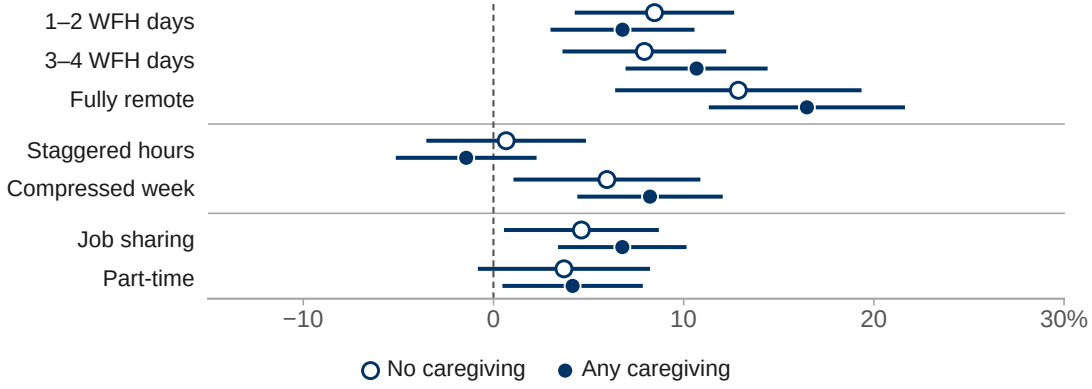


Aged 40+ give up less for staggered hours (7 points, p = .02); nothing else is significant at 5%.

PME groups

Backup index

Estimates by caregiving



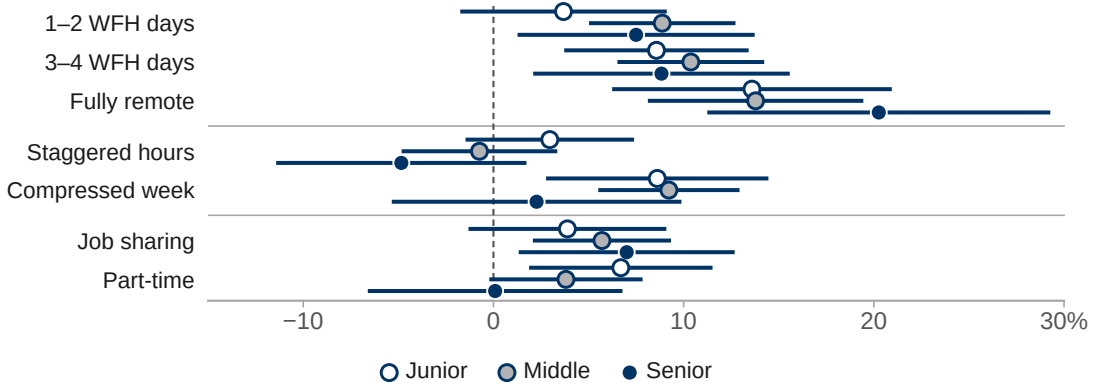
No difference is significant at 5%.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B29

Estimates by role level

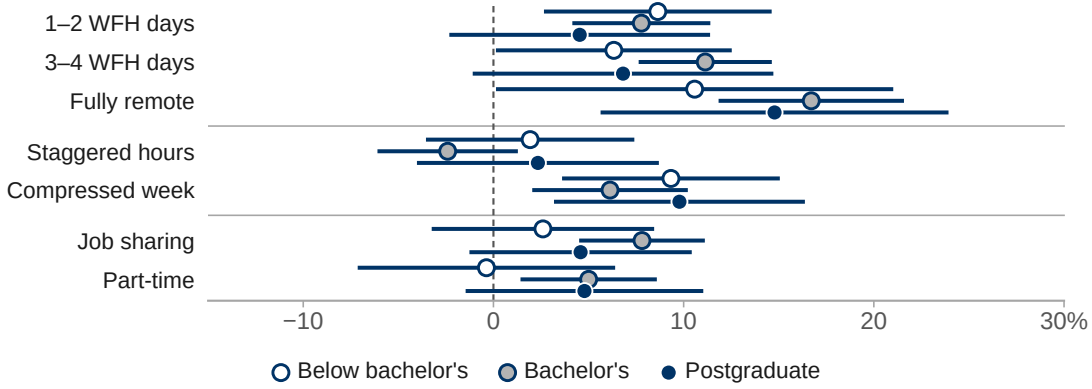


No difference is significant at 5%.

PME groups

Backup index

Estimates by education



No difference is significant at 5%.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B31

PME splits by seven characteristics

Split (A / B)	n	1–2 days	3–4 days	Remote	Compressed
Career penalty: y / n	455 / 565	2 / 10	2 / 14	9 / 19	10 / 6
Commute $>$ / $\leq$45 min	305 / 681	6 / 8	10 / 8	11 / 22	6 / 8
WFH now: y / n	666 / 338	9 / 5	12 / 5	19 / 10	8 / 6
Pay $>$ / $\leq$S$6,000	408 / 435	8 / 7	11 / 10	17 / 13	9 / 6
Public / local / MNC	171/383/412	8/9/7	6/11/9	21/15/14	7/7/8
Tenure: 3+ / $<$3 years	805 / 199	7 / 6	9 / 12	15 / 15	7 / 8
Mothers, child 0–6 / rest	108 / 912	11 / 7	17 / 9	21 / 14	7 / 7

Reading: the career-concern split shows the clearest difference in WFH values; it was asked after the choices, so part of the gap may be choice noise.

◂ Career concerns ◂ PME groups

Backup index

Backup B32

Valued more where offered? Not robust

Arrangement	Offered	Not offered	Difference	Take-up, %
WFH (any level)		valued equally either way		87
Staggered hours	≈ 0	≈ -2	n.s. (p = .60)	69
Compressed week	≈ 15	≈ 6	+9 (p = .004), *not robust*[1]	31
Compressed, separate slopes[1]	–	–	+5.5 [−4.4, 15.4] (p = .27)	
Job sharing	≈ 7	≈ 6	n.s. (p = .82)	27
Part-time	≈ 15	≈ 2	+13 (p $<$.001), *not robust*[2]	26

% of pay, one pay slope for both groups. [1] *Not robust*: not significant with separate pay slopes. [2]Not re-estimated; treated as not robust. N = 983 employed PMEs. Take-up = use among those with access. Grey = indicative.

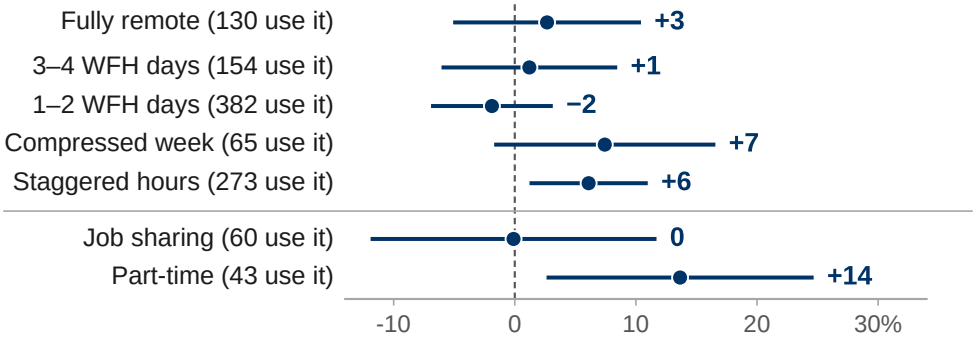
Significant only under a common pay slope; PMEs with access are less pay-sensitive (log-pay coefficient 2.79 vs 4.70).

◂ Puzzle ◂ Groups

Backup index

Backup B33

Current users value part-time and staggered hours more



Users give up more for part-time (14 points) and staggered hours (6), but not for WFH.

Current use

Raw choices, before any model

	PMEs: flexible job		Employers: flexible hire	
% choosing it (n)	**paid less**	**paid more**	**cheaper**	**dearer**
1–2 days WFH	27 (350)	88 (170)	48 (172)	34 (90)
3–4 days WFH	23 (407)	81 (167)	39 (152)	30 (73)
Fully remote	43 (320)	80 (116)	39 (110)	8 (37)
Staggered hours	22 (921)	76 (334)	61 (315)	–
Compressed week	24 (768)	87 (122)	60 (209)	37 (41)
Reduced load / job sharing	25 (641)	80 (458)	58 (239)	32 (145)
Part-time	28 (691)	80 (223)	40 (233)	24 (164)
Chose the better-paid option[1]	75 (6,120)		58 (2,382)	
Better on both other features, paid less	28 (2,563)		–	

Arrangement vs its base; pay differed by 17–33%. [1] PMEs: higher-paid offer; employers: cheaper candidate.

◂ Two sides ◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B35

Why employer % is secondary

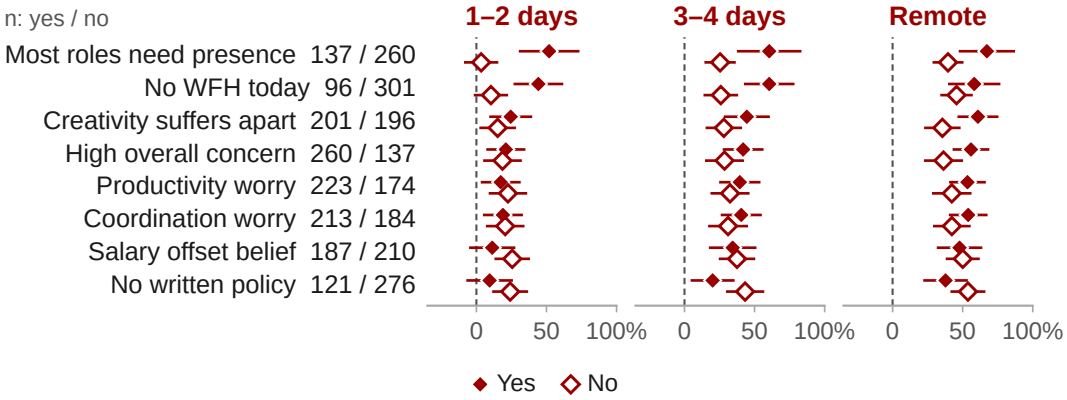
	PMEs	Employers
Chose the better-paid option, %[1]	75	58
... by gap tercile (small/mid/large)	74 / 76 / 74	57 / 59 / 57
Log-likelihood: log salary	−3,417.2	−1,526.9
Log-likelihood: which paid more	−3,414.1	−1,527.2
Log salary adds to ‘which paid more’ (p)	$<.001$	.19
‘Which paid more’ adds to log salary (p)	$<.001$	.31
Fully remote vs the 17–33% gaps shown	below ($\approx 15^2$)	beyond the largest (33%)

Holding other features fixed, PMEs respond more to larger pay gaps (p = .014), employers do not (p = .50). [1]PMEs: higher-paid offer; employers: cheaper candidate. [2]PMEs: vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

Pay-cut sizes rest on a weakly identified pay slope; the ranking is firmer.

◂ Employers

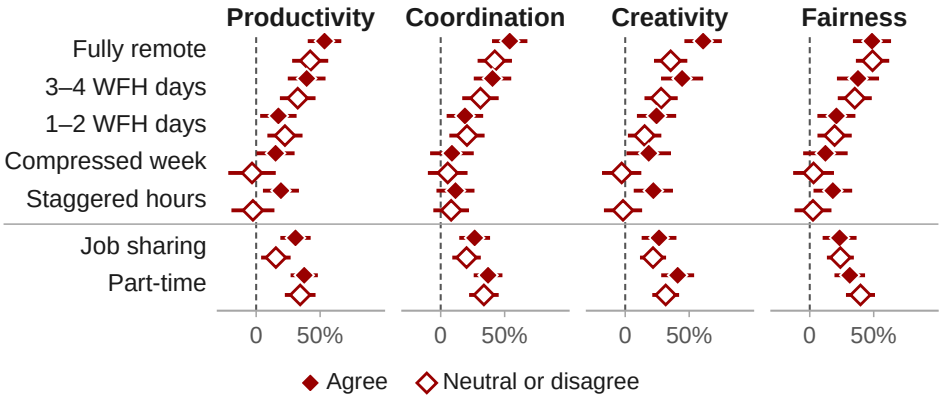
All employer splits



Pay cut required, 95% CI; yes = as labelled (agree = 4–5 of 5). Asked after the choices.

On-site needs

Four concerns: only creativity shows a signal



Agree = 4–5 of 5; neutral or disagree = 1–3. $p < .05$ only for creativity; not corrected for 28 comparisons.

Concerns

Backup index

Backup B38

Concerns are common; creativity shows a weak link

Employer view (agree = 4–5 of 5)	Agree, %	Linked to the WFH choice?
Worry staff are less productive at home	56	No detectable link
Hybrid creates coordination problems	54	No detectable link
Creativity suffers when people are apart	51	Weak link: agreeing firms require a 61% vs 36% pay cut for remote
High overall concern (index $>$ 3)	65[1]	No detectable link

Creativity: n = 201 vs 196; not significant after correction for the 11 employer split tests. [1]Mean of the three items; 75% agree with at least one. Associations, not causes.

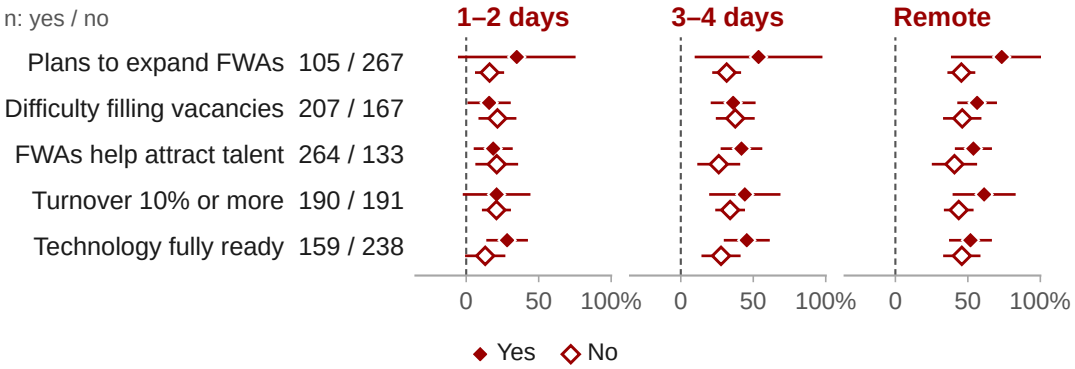
Agree = 4–5 of 5.

◂ Concerns

Backup index

Backup B39

Employer values by other firm characteristics



Pay cut required, 95% CI; yes = as labelled (agree = 4–5 of 5).

On-site needs

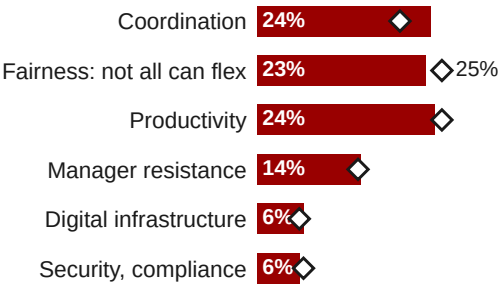
Backup index

Backup B40

Employers: talent upside, practical hurdles

Biggest FWA challenge

% of employers ◇ ≤200 staff (n = 175)

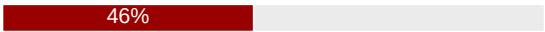


Other: 3%.

FWAs help attract, retain talent (agree)



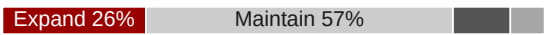
Unfair if frontline can't have FWAs (agree)



Hard to fill PME vacancies (past year)



12-month FWA plan



Tech-ready for remote work



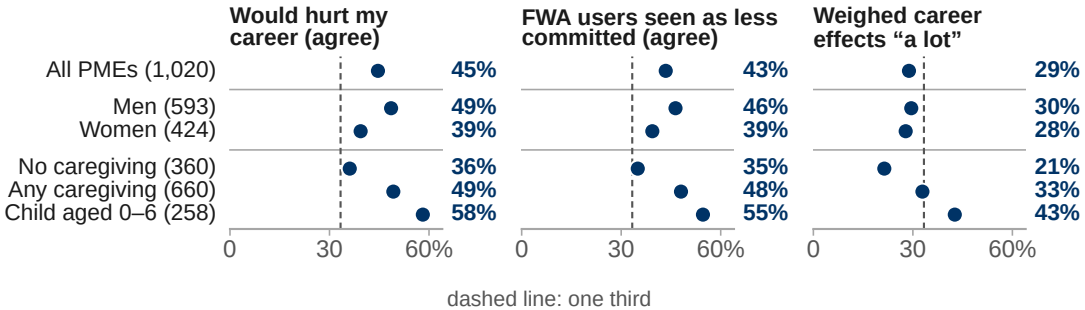
No size association in hiring choices; compressed-week offering rises with firm size (14, 18, 26%; p = .07).

◂ Challenges ◂ Concerns

Backup index

Backup B41

Over a third of surveyed PMEs expect a career penalty



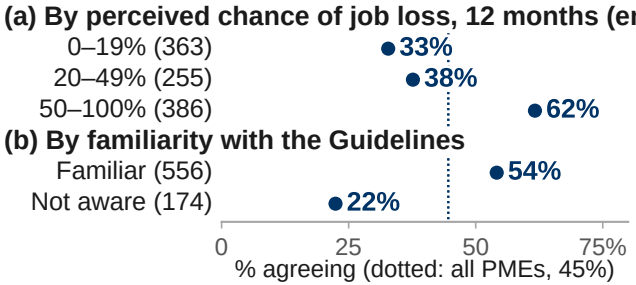
Agree = 4–5 of 5: an expected penalty, not a reported setback. Who expects it.

◂ Barriers ◂ Why PMEs

Backup index

Backup B42

Who expects a career penalty?



(c) Formal request reported (employed, aware)

Expecting a penalty is associated with **+15 pp [9, 20]** after controls.

Full approval: no detectable difference (p = .44).

(c) Request item partly misread; asking may shape the belief.

Job-loss chance: a relative index, not a probability. Associations, not causes.
(b) Gap about halves with formal requests held fixed.

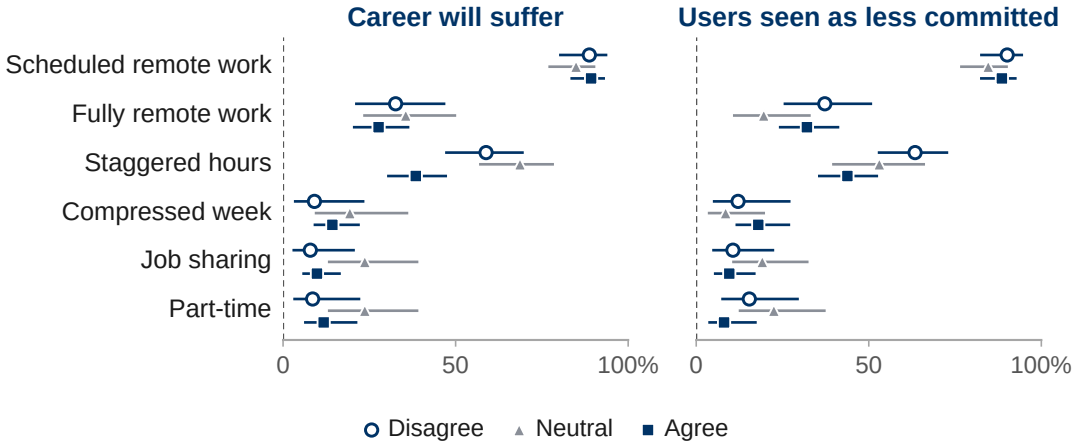
Parents of 0–6s: +12 pp after controls (p = .001). **MOM:** about 6% of resident FWA users reported a setback in 2025 (reported experience, not expectation).

Agree = 4–5 of 5. Job loss: self-rated 12-month chance. Chart.

◂ Barriers ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

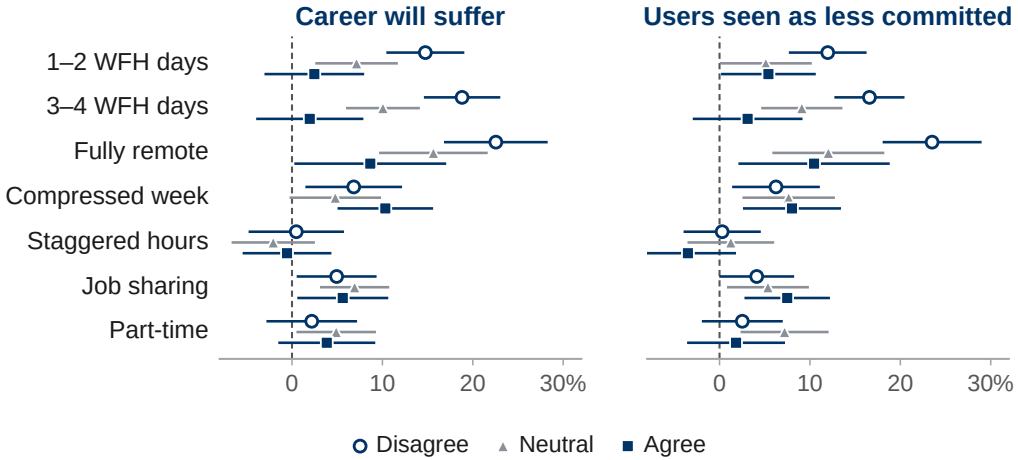
Use among PMEs with access, by career worry and stigma



Share using, among PMEs with the arrangement available; 95% CI. Career: “working shorter or more flexible hours would negatively affect my career”. Stigma: “users are seen as less committed”.

Career concerns

Pay PMEs would give up, by career worry and stigma



Disagree = 1–2, neutral = 3, agree = 4–5.

Career concerns

Access, use and career worry by job level

	Junior	Middle	Senior
At least one of the five FWAs available	80%	85%	94%
Using at least one	66%	72%	80%
Use, among those with access	82%	84%	85%
Know the Guidelines' key provisions	29%	52%	77%
Expect flexible work to hurt their career	36%	45%	52%

Employed PMEs (n = 215, 473, 316). Five FWAs: WFH, staggered hours, compressed week, job sharing, part-time.

◂ Levels ◂ By level

Backup index

Backup B46

What we can say about the Guidelines

What we observe (2026)

- Familiar: 55% of surveyed PMEs, 29% of juniors, 58% of employers
- Of PMEs reporting a formal request, 4% were declined (7%, stricter definition): a lower bound
- More FWAs came via company policy (43%) than individual request (30%)
- Aware firms with a written policy got more requests (68% vs 19%; an association)

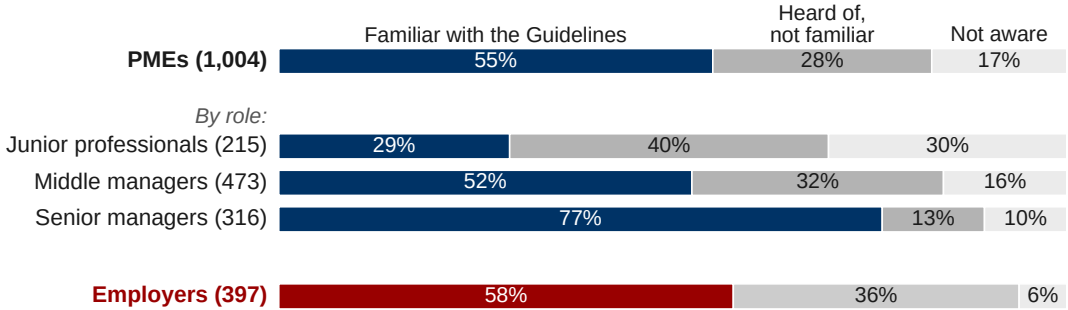
What we cannot say

- Whether the Guidelines changed outcomes (no before-and-after)
- National rates (unweighted panels)
- Why PMEs do not ask (not asked)
- How firms decide staff requests (experiment: hiring)

▸ Approvals ▸ Awareness ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Awareness is wide but shallow



PMEs: employed (n). Unweighted.
PAP–NTUC survey's 58% aware: not comparable.

PAP Women's Wing–NTUC survey (online, Nov–Dec 2025): 58% aware; 29% know where to turn if a request is denied.

Barriers

Same process, two vantage points

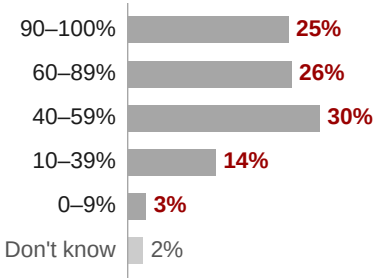
PMEs reporting a formal request

Reported outcome, %



Employers: share of requests approved

(n = 203)



Unweighted.

MOM, for comparison (definitions differ): ≈94% approved (2024 data, almost entirely before the Guidelines). After use, ≈6% of resident FWA users reported a career setback (2025): experience, not PMEs' expectation.

Different questions: PMEs report their own request; employers, their firm's approval share. Excluding automatic FWAs, 6.9% of PMEs' requests were declined (why).

Barriers

Why no headline request rate

Base	n	Made a formal request, %
Employed and aware of the Guidelines	832	65.7
All employed (not aware = no request)	1,004	54.5
FWA automatic by company policy	318	72.3

“Formal” was undefined and there was no “automatic” option.

◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B50

The compressed week: valued, rarely offered

Both sides: about the same

7%

vs 7%

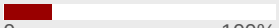


of pay: PMEs give up vs employers require

Few firms offer it

1 in 6

18%



of surveyed firms offer it to PMEs

Goes with a written FWA policy

21.4%

vs 9.1%

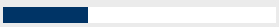


of firms with / without a written policy offer it

Take-up where available

1 in 3

31%



of PMEs with access use it

PMEs would give up about 7% of pay for it, yet few firms offer it.
A voluntary, evaluated pilot is the next step.

▸ Offering ▸ Pilot checklist

Backup index

Backup B51

Compressed week: design balance, offering, use

Design: usually the cheaper option

The lower-paid option in 83% of PME and 91% of employer pairs.

% chosen if	cheaper	dearer
PMEs: compressed	27.5	85.5
PMEs: others	24.9	75.1
Firms: compressed	67	37[c]
Firms: others	56	44

PMEs: consistent with a positive value at either price. **Firms:** mixed; "no detectable penalty" rests mainly on cheaper candidates.

Operating costs unmeasured: pilot checklist.

Surveyed firms offering it (70 of 397)

Trait	% offer	OR [95% CI]
Written policy	21.4 vs 9.1	**2.41** [1.20, 4.87]
Offers part-time[a]		**3.03** [1.67, 5.51]
Presence need		1.53 [0.88, 2.66]
Fully tech-ready		0.83 [0.48, 1.43]
Productivity concern[b]		1.61 [0.77, 3.37]
Hard to hire	18.4 vs 16.8	p = .69
Size: ≤200 / 201–1,000 / 1,001+	13.7 / 17.9 / 25.6	p = .066

Surveyed PMEs: access 21%; take-up 31%; career concern OR 0.86 [0.44, 1.67].

ORs from a logit (N = 397); policy may follow offering. [a]With other offerings (policy OR 2.16 [1.04, 4.49]). [b]With concerns, talent view, hiring, turnover: p ≥ .16. [c]41 pairs.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Directions

Backup index

Backup B52

Flexi-load: mostly pay for hours

Model-dependent; not a pay recommendation and not a main finding.

	Reduced load / job sharing[1]	Part-time
PMEs: pay given up, % of pay (95% CI)	≈6 (3–9)	≈4 (1–7)
Employers: pay cut required, %	≈24	36
Gap, % of pay	≈18	≈32
Employed PMEs using it, %	6	4
Take-up with access, %[2]	27	26

[1] Employers saw “reduced load”, PMEs “job sharing”. [2] Among employed PMEs with access. Grey = indicative.

◂ Two sides ◂ Directions

Backup index

A compressed-week pilot: checklist

Design

- Same hours, four longer days; pay and leave unchanged
- Legal, contract and collective-agreement review
- Voluntary for firms and staff; reversible without penalty
- Eligibility; fairness to staff who cannot join

Safeguards

- Service and coverage plan
- Fatigue, safety and care hours
- Workload spillovers
- Appraisal by output, not presence

Evaluation

- Outcomes: output, operating costs, coverage, retention, take-up, worker experience
- Stop and scale criteria agreed with the partners in advance
- Independent evaluation with a comparison group; worker data only with consent, never for appraisal

Why a pilot: most promising common-ground test; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured.

To agree: number of firms, duration, comparison group, funder, data access, report-back date.

Possible leads: SNEF with volunteer firms; NTUC co-designs safeguards; TAFEP guidance.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Directions

Backup index

Rankings are more credible than levels

Check	Concern	Result
Pay outliers; 1% trim	Implausible pay	Arrangements: about 1 point or less, both sides
Same-side answers	Inattention	PMEs: about 1 point or less; employers: up to 3 points
Position term	Left-option bias	Arrangements: at most 2 points, both sides
Version clusters	Only 60 choice situations	Holds, except employer staggered hours (p = .15)
Rank pay model	How pay enters	Fits about as well on both sides; same ranking

The rankings hold under every check;
the exact % of pay values are less certain.

▸ Validity ▸ Checks

PME values stay positive

	Main	Excl. outliers	1% trim	Excl. same-side	Position term	Version CI
N	1,020	891	1,007	947	1,020	1,020
1–2 days WFH	≈7.4	≈7.4	≈7.4	≈6.5	≈7.9	5–10
3–4 days WFH	≈9.5	≈10.2	≈9.5	≈9.1	≈10.0	5–14
Fully remote	≈15.1	≈14.8	≈14.9	≈14.8	≈15.8	11–19
Compressed week	≈7.4	≈7.6	≈7.4	≈8.2	≈6.7	4–11
Staggered hours	≈−0.7	≈−0.6	≈−0.8	≈−0.5	≈0.6	−5–3
Job sharing	≈6.0	≈6.3	≈6.3	≈5.5	≈5.9	3–9
Part-time	≈3.9	≈4.9	≈4.2	≈2.9	≈5.1	2–6

% of pay given up. Version CI: 95% CI clustered by survey version.

Outliers: implausible salaries dropped. Same-side: always chose one side.

◂ Robustness ◂ PMEs

Backup index

Backup B56

Employer values hold in every sample

	Main	Excl. outliers	1% trim	Excl. same-side
N	397	392	391	381
1–2 days WFH	≈19.7	≈19.7	≈20.2	≈18.9
3–4 days WFH	≈35.8	≈35.7	≈36.1	≈35.3
Fully remote	≈48.7	≈48.8	≈49.0	≈47.5
Compressed week	≈7.0	≈7.2	≈6.4	≈4.4
Staggered hours	≈10.0	≈9.2	≈8.9	≈10.5
Reduced load	≈23.6	≈23.6	≈23.5	≈23.4
Part-time	≈35.5	≈35.2	≈34.9	≈34.0

% pay cut employers would require. Outliers: implausible salaries; same-side: always chose one side.

◂ Robustness ◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B57

Limits in detail

Limit	What it means	Next step
Pay gaps 17–33%	% of pay is model-based; employers weakly pay-sensitive (cheaper won 58%)	A small-gap wave
60 design cells	10 versions $\times$ 6 tasks per side: intervals likely too narrow	Cluster by version
Compressed week	Cheaper in 83% (PME) and 91% (employer) of its pairs	Balance pay positions
Employer splits	Preliminary associations, asked after the choices	Ask these items before the choices
Employer task	A hire, not a staff request; not an operating cost	Pilots that record operations
Samples	Unweighted panels, mostly large firms	Items in MOM surveys
Request item	Misread; refusals among askers only; no why-not item	Direction E items

Also: stated choices (SNEF use known); no before-and-after; 12% of salaries capped; task-1 coding.

◂ Robustness

Backup index

Follow-up design, if supported

	Aim 1: do stated choices predict behaviour?	Aim 2: what changes in firms that adopt?
Outcomes	FWA take-up, job moves, promotion, appraisal vs each PME's choices	Productivity, retention, hires, exits in volunteer pilot firms (Directions A, C), vs a comparison group
Consent now	490 of 1,020 PMEs (48%) agreed to one short (about 5-minute) survey in 6–12 months (Feb–Aug 2027)	None: the employer survey asked no re-contact question
Partner roles	**NTUC:** reach members beyond online panels; **MOM:** linkage only with fresh consent, under its data rules	**SNEF:** recruit fresh volunteer member firms; **MOM:** firm linkage only with consent
Templates	Maestas et al.: 56% matched up to 3 years later (validity)	Trip.com hybrid trial: quits fell 7.20% to 4.80%; German LPP: consented employer–employee linkage, six waves 2012–2024

Consent scope: 490 PMEs consented to one short survey in 6–12 months; further waves, linkage and firm-side work require fresh consent.

Consenters lean to caregivers (52.6% vs 39.7% agreed).

◂ Summary

Backup index

Direction A: test the compressed week

Direction: A **Strength:** moderate; operating costs unmeasured

The evidence

PMEs would give up about 7% of pay for it; employers would require about 7% (wide interval): no detectable gap. 1 surveyed firm in 6 offers it, more often with a written policy (21% vs 9%). It was the cheaper option in 83% (PME) and 91% (employer) of its pairs.

Owner and first step

SNEF, with volunteer member firms: put it on the written menu and test it in a bounded, evaluated pilot (checklist). **NTUC:** co-design safeguards. **TAFEP:** guidance.

Builds on

TAFEP and IHRP resources; SNEF guidance on FWA requests.

What it is not

Not shorter hours (same hours, four longer days), a mandate or a case for lower pay; not shown to be costless.

What to watch

Output, coverage, rostering, fatigue; take-up where available (31%).

◂ Directions ◂ Puzzle

Backup index

Backup B60

Direction B: match arrangements to roles

Direction: B **Strength:** exploratory; preliminary associations

The evidence

Where most roles need presence, firms would require a pay cut of about 52% for 1–2 WFH days, against 3% where only some or few do (PMEs would give up about 7%; PMEs were not asked about presence). A compressed week: about 1%. Preliminary.

Owner and first step

Firms, with SNEF: review which tasks need presence; start with 1–2 WFH days where roles allow; a compressed week may fit where WFH does not; use flexi-load where fewer hours, not location, address the need. Job Redesign+: up to 70% of qualifying costs for SMEs, 50% for others. **MOM:** PTRG review.

Associations; asked after the choices. Flexi-load.

Builds on

EWTP (Mar 2026), linked by MOM to FWAs.

What it is not

Not one-size-fits-all; not a quota.

What to watch

Fairness to staff without FWAs (top challenge, $\leq$200 staff); part-time access (COS 2026: under half who needed it got it).

◂ Directions ◂ On-site needs

Backup index

Backup B61

Direction C: support managers and HR

Direction: C **Strength:** exploratory; associations, and the effect of training is untested

The evidence

Employers' main challenge: productivity 24%, coordination 24%, fairness 23%, managerial resistance or trust 14%; digital infrastructure and security 6% each (one answer each). Concern levels do not reliably change the pay cut. 45% of PMEs expect flexible work to hurt their career (36% of juniors, 52% of seniors); they value WFH much less and, where staggered hours are available, use them less (38% vs 59–69%).

Owner and first step

TAFEP, NTUC and member firms: guidance and training for HR and managers on FWA requests and on appraising by output; try it with volunteer firms.

Builds on

TAFEP and IHRP resources; SNEF guidance on FWA requests; 58% of employers say they know the Guidelines.

What it is not

Not a new reporting duty for firms; not shown to change appraisal or use.

What to watch

Fairness to staff without FWAs; whether career worry falls and use rises.

Associations; concern items were asked after the choices. Technology rarely named as the main challenge is not shown to be no hurdle.

◂ Directions ◂ Challenges

Backup index

Direction D: open access and information for juniors

Direction: D **Strength:** exploratory; descriptive

The evidence

At least one of five arrangements available: 80% of junior professionals, 85% of middle and 94% of senior management; in use: 66%, 72%, 80%. Use among those with access is similar (82–85%), so the gap is access. Familiar with the key provisions of the Guidelines: 29%, 52%, 77%. WFH values are alike across levels. Most FWAs arrive through company policy (43%) rather than an individual request (30%).

Owner and first step

Member firms, with MOM and NTUC outreach: check whether junior roles can use the arrangements the firm already has, and tell juniors about the Guidelines through the usual channel, the company policy.

Descriptive (see by level).

Builds on

Company policies; MOM and NTUC communication channels.

What it is not

Not a new entitlement; not evidence that leaders' use spreads to juniors.

What to watch

Access and familiarity among juniors; take-up among those with access.

◂ Directions ◂ By level

Backup index

Direction E: measure what is missing

Direction: E **Strength:** gap documented

The evidence

Firms need not report requests to MOM; in MOM's survey, 18.5% of those needing an FWA made a formal request (data for 2024). MOM publishes request rates, not reasons; our survey had no why-not item, and our request item was partly misread. Of PMEs reporting a request, about 4% were declined (a lower bound) and 32% partly approved. 45% expect a career penalty; it goes with more requests, not fewer.

Owner and first step

MOM (MRSD), with NTUC and SNEF: check its survey, then add the items not yet asked: why those who need an FWA do not ask, and whether a request was approved in full, with changes, or declined (draft).

Follow-up.

Builds on

MOM's employee survey; partners' outreach channels.

What it is not

Not a new reporting duty for firms; not an evaluation of the Guidelines.

What to watch

Partial approvals; junior PMEs' awareness (29% familiar); expected penalty vs MOM's reported setbacks ($\approx$6% of FWA users, 2025).

◂ Directions ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B64

Direction E: draft survey items

First step (employees)

1. **Why not ask:** if you needed an FWA but did not request one, why not? (career concern; did not know how; expected refusal; automatic)
2. **Outcome:** approved as requested / with changes / declined.

Also (employees)

3. Formal request: add “applies automatically”.
4. Guidelines awareness; would flexible work affect your career?

Later, if partners agree (establishments)

5. Any formal FWA request in the past 12 months?
6. Share approved as requested, with changes, or declined?
7. Roles needing on-site presence: which arrangements are offered?

Draft for MRSD, to check against EWC and CoE questionnaires; item 1 appears new.

◂ Directions ◂ Summary

Backup index

Backup B65